Apart from the changes in the language and the libraries, some of my personal opinions also changed since the first edition of this book. I learned to be wary of some techniques, such as *Ghost Methods (57)*, and fonder of others, such as *Dynamic Methods (51)*. Parts of the new text reflect these changes of heart.

Finally, this second edition is a general cleanup of the first edition's text. I updated many examples that were using gems and source code that have been forgotten or changed since the previous book; I added a few spells and removed a few others that don't seem very relevant anymore; I toned down the "story" in the text when it was adding too many words to long technical explanations; and I went through every sentence again, fixing things that needed fixing and addressing errata and suggestions from the readers. Whether you're a new reader or a fan of the first edition, I hope you like the result.

About You

Most people consider metaprogramming an advanced topic. To play with the constructs of a Ruby program, you have to know how these constructs work in the first place. How do you know whether you're enough of an "advanced" Rubyist to deal with metaprogramming? Well, if you can understand the code in the very first chapter without much trouble, then you are well equipped to move forward.

If you're not confident about your skills, you can take a simple self-test. Which kind of code would you write to iterate over an array? If you thought about the `each` method, then you know enough Ruby to follow the ensuing text. If you thought about the `for` keyword, then you're probably new to Ruby. In the second case, you can still embark on this metaprogramming adventure—just take an introductory Ruby text along with you, or take the excellent interactive tutorial at the *Try Ruby!* site.[4]

Are you on board, then? Great! Let's start.

4. http://tryruby.org